

SUBZEROEDIT

One of the most famous racehorses in Australia was Sub-Zero, who won the prestigious Melbourne Cup race back in the 90s. Sadly, he passed away back in 2020, and I recorded an interview with one of the owners of the horse pre-COVID. My guest this week is Alan Broderib, and Alan is the owner of a very famous Australian racehorse, indeed a Melbourne Cup winner, and probably one of the most famous racehorses in Australia, Sub-Zero.

Alan, welcome to the program. Thank you, Geoff, it's a pleasure to be here with you. Tell us a little bit about Sub-Zero.

When it was a foal, did you acquire it as a foal, or how did that happen? No, I met Lee Friedman just before the Magic Minion sales, and I had been buying my own horses with no success, so I thought, I better leave it to somebody that's a bit successful. So I decided to go into a horse with Lee. So we just went from there, and he happened to buy Sub-Zero at the sales.

It was a good-looking grey out of a mare, which took up the whole page. And it's very, very rarely that you see a dam that takes up the full page on a breeding sheet. The only thing I didn't look at was I didn't look at the horse, and Lee had already bought it, so I said, I'll have a leg.

When you met Sub-Zero for the first time, what sort of feeling did you have from the horse? What sort of energy did he give out to you? Well, he was a grey, so of course he's very colourful being a grey. So he did emit a different type of energy, and he was a very athletic-looking horse. We did buy him thinking he'd be a sprinter, but unfortunately he couldn't sprint to save himself.

So Lee, in one of his dry moments, said, don't worry, you'll make him a stay. You can have more fun with stays. You can watch them longer.

To this day, I don't know what that means in racing age, because stays do race on longer than sprinters. Or in the distance of a race, which is longer than being a staying race. And this was back in 1988-89, I suppose, when he was a one-year-old.

1990 at the sales, I think we bought him. If I had looked more carefully at the pedigree, I wouldn't have been involved because he was out of a 21-year-old mare, which is extremely old. Any good judge will tell you, don't buy out of old mares.

But we didn't know that, and away we went. I had had horses previously, which had not successful, so I left it to Lee. How did it come about that Sub-Zero got into the Melbourne Cup? The first two years as a two-year-old, he couldn't race.

Well, he did race, but he was unsuccessful. An early two-year-old then, when he was approaching his three-year-old age in June of that year, he won his first race at Flemington over 1,600 metres. Then two weeks later, we backed him up over 2,000 metres at Flemington, and he

won again.

Was that one them that we worked out? Well, obviously, the horses are stayer, so we'll train him as a stayer, which you do train differently. Stayers have slow twitch muscles, which they use, and sprinters are trained to use quick twitch muscles. Same as in athletes, sprinters and distant runners, they use different muscles, and they're differently conformed.

The personality of the horse is incredible. I mean, when people have seen Sub-Zero in person or in reality, he's got such a tremendous heart and personality, hasn't he? Well, you may as well say in person, because we're sure that he has been here before. He is now employed by Racing Victoria as a comfort horse.

He goes round old people's homes and schools and talks to children and old people. That's quite amazing. You can put two or three wheelchairs under his legs, and he won't budge.

He's never plotted his copybook anywhere. He's a sensation. He is a freak.

He is something different. That's quite amazing to think that he was one of the leading thoroughbreds in the country in his time, and now he's fully involved doing this, and he's still doing it, and he's very happy doing it at the age of 26. And tell us about that fantastic day in 1992 at Flemington.

Well, when four lucky fellows just get together and buy a horse, you don't think this is going to happen. He did win the Adelaide Derby very comfortably, then he won the Adelaide Cup in scintillating style. He beat all the horses, and he won that with a record wait for a three-year-old.

After the race, I was talking with Bart Cummings, and Bart said, I don't know what you're worried about. He said, you'll win the Melbourne Cup on that run. Well, we all forget these things as time goes on.

Lee said the same. When we were in the presentation of the Adelaide Cup, he said, see all those photographers there. He said, you ain't seen nothing yet.

Wait till the first Tuesday in November. But these are just trainers throwing words at you, and of course it doesn't happen. Four lucky mugs just don't get together and finish up with a Melbourne Cup horse.

We did pay good money for him. He was \$100,000 a yearling, but you just don't do it. People have spent millions trying to breed a Melbourne Cup runner, let alone a Melbourne Cup winner.

But anyway, the rest is history. And his race winnings were up over \$2 million, and it was a very good result for four lucky mugs who got together. Yes, we can thank our trainer at the time, Lee Friedman, for that.

And can't leave out Greg Hall, our jockey, who rode him to most of his wins, including all the big ones. Greg on his day was good as anybody in the world. I don't believe he had any peer anywhere in the world, Greg Hall as a jockey.

Now Sub-Zero post-Melbourne Cup became the Clarke of Horse horse at Flemington for a long time. And then he got a bit of arthritis, and tell us about that. Yes, well Graham Salisbury, one of the clerks of the course at Flemington, had his eye on Subby from his three-year-old as a horse, which he thought had the future to be Clarke of the Horse Horse.

So when he retired, he went straight to Graham Salisbury, and Salisbury changed him around and made him a Clarke of the Course, and taught him all the tricks that he does today. And that is things like he actually gives girls kisses, and he actually bends down on one knee to say hello, and does bows, and all sorts of things. Yes, you can do all those things.

I do believe at one stage, Graham Salisbury did teach him to sit on a garden seat. He sat on it one day, and it broke under him, and of course he's been a bit ginger about jumping on a garden seat ever since. And I do think that's probably true.

He's quite amazing. He's even been to Dubai. One of the shakes saw him here in Australia one year over the Melbourne Cup Carnival, and couldn't believe that a thoroughbred could do this.

So he sponsored the horse to go to Dubai to lead out the World Cup field, then bowed to the shake while the field was on their way to the barrier. About the arthritis, he did get a bit of a health problem, but that's been solved. And tell us a little bit about that.

Yes, well he's always been a bit diggy in the knees, as a lot of thoroughbreds are, and as ages caught up with him, he did get very arthritic. And he had a special potion, a powder which was coming in from America. The authorities, I think it was the customs people, decided not to let it come in.

It wasn't approved in Australia for anything. So Subby called on a few of his friends being politicians and such, and I think the Premier of Victoria became heavily involved. And Subby, of course, is quite friendly with John Howard.

They've met on numerous occasions. And Sir William Dean, who was the Governor-General of Australia. So by pulling a few strings, Subby managed to get his lovely magic potion into Australia, and he still uses it to this day, and his blood count is spot on.

If he wasn't 26 years old, you wouldn't know it. He's fit enough in the blood count and physically to go around in a race. And what's the future for Sub-Zero now? Well, at the moment there's a book, one of the broadcasters in Melbourne, Adam Crittenden, who's a young fellow.

He's writing a book on Subby. It'll be very interesting. I'm happy he doesn't say too much about

Subby's girlfriends.

He's had a few flings with quite a few well-known singing personalities and politicians and such. He meets a lot of people. He gets up on the roof of Crown Casino each year around the Melbourne Cup time and meets a lot of personalities.

He also goes on stage at Crown and usually tips the Melbourne Cup winner. Brilliant. Well, Alan, I'm sure that Sub-Zero has a very long future still to go yet, but he also will be in the hearts and minds of Australians and race fans all over the world for a long time to come.

Yes, he's extremely well-known, and we've just forced sport-lucky fellows that happen to be involved with this horse, who's now become really a legend in Australian racing. Alan Broderib, the owner of Sub-Zero, thank you very much for being with us on the program. My pleasure, Geoff, any time.

Thank you.